

The Boy Who Loved Words

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There are, in this world, people who are born collectors. Some collect shells or stones. Others, feathers. Some have even been known to collect tiny teaspoons. Such a one was Selig. He was a collector of words.

Selig loved everything about words - the sound of them in his ears (tintinnabulating!), the taste of them on his tongue (tantalizing!), the thought of them when they percolated in his brain (stirring!), and, most especially, the feel of them when they moved his heart (Mama!).

Whenever Selig heard a word he liked, he'd shout it loud, jot it down on a slip of paper, then stuff it into his pocket to save. Such a collector! Selig's pockets positively brimmed with words. He stuffed new ones inside his shirt, down his socks, up his sleeves, under his hat.

While other children busied themselves with bats, nets, and all manner of balls, Selig stayed on the outskirts, always on the periphery - collecting delicious words.

His father, a dutiful man who sold sturdy shoes for a living, wondered what good could possibly come from a son with such a strange predilection.

His mother, a large, lovely woman from the Old Country, worried - could her beautiful boy find happiness? Waving her arms in the air, she was a windmill of worry.

As time went on, people began calling Selig by a new name: Wordsworth. "Hey, Wordsworth," kids would giggle. "Here's a word for your collection - oddball!" "Oddball!" Selig repeated. The silly-sounding word should have made him giggle, but instead it left him lonely.

One night, Selig had a dream.... Alone, in front of an unusual emporium, he encountered an oversized amphora. Curious, Selig gave it a tap. Swoooooooooosh! Out popped a swarthy, swirling man. "Djinn!" Selig exclaimed, then, "Genie!" he shouted, enjoying the tang of tasty new words.

"Vhat you vant?" the Genie asked. "A vish?" Such strange and savory sounds! Such an offer! At a loss for words, Selig suddenly knew his vish - it was for an answer. "Is it true, am I really... an... oddball?"

"Oddball? Feh! You are Voidsvoith, a lover of voids. Already you have vhat people search their whole life for - an enthusiasm, a passion. Vhat you need now is a poipose, a mission." Then, without a word of warning, the Genie disappeared.

Selig awakened from his dream.... Lickety-split, he packed a rucksack with a pillow and blanket, apples, honey, cream soda, and his entire collection of words. He knew exactly what he had to do. Selig took to the road, determined to find his purpose.

On the trail of his purpose, Selig's senses sharpened. He noted the nod and toddle of tulips in the wind; the sway and swagger of tree branches; how, at evening, the light dimmed to announce the arrival of twilight and stars. Dusk, Selig noted, adding that short and enchanting word to his collection.

But in time Selig's step grew heavy. Under the weight of so many words, it was harder and harder to move. He was shuffling and shambling when he might have been rambling and ambling. Perhaps what he needed to do was lighten his load. But HOW? Throw words away? Waste them? Impossible! They were far too precious!

Selig was too tired to think. His exhausted brain could imagine but one thing - slumber, a splendid word! Sadly, he was too sleepy to write it down.

In front of Selig stood a large and lovely tree. He removed his jacket, stuffed, like his mama's strudel, with words. Tenderly, he hung each word on its own separate branch, as if putting it to bed for the night.

With a sip of cream soda and a nibble of honeyed apple, Selig clambered, then curled in a crook of the tree. Snug, he thought, and fell directly to sleep. Comfortably cradled there, he dreamed of his mama, his mission, and macaroons - his favorite cookie.

During the night, a pacing poet, unable to sleep for want of a word, found himself under the same tree, gazing hopelessly at the moon. Night after night, he'd been struggling to find the right words to describe it.

Suddenly, mysteriously, a swirling wind blew up. Four of Selig's words sailed off their branches. Reaching skyward, the distracted poet caught them. Discarding the word macaroon, he held tightly to lozenge, lemon, and licorice. "The moon," he wrote in his notebook, growing more and more excited with each word, "melted like a lemon lozenge in the licorice sky." "My stars!" the poet shouted, exultant. "That's it!"

The following morning Selig awoke to what could only be called a rhapsody of birds and words. The poet was reading his newest poem aloud - a poem chockablock with Selig's words!

Wiping the sleep crumbs from his eyes, Selig scrambled down the tree and saluted the poet. "Your poem," he told him, "contains some of my favorite words. How beautifully you use them."

"Why, thank you. For once, the words just seemed to come to me. Upon my word! How lucky I am! What, may I ask, is your name? I should like to dedicate my poem to you."

For a moment, Selig hesitated. Then, suddenly, for the first time ever, he proudly proclaimed, "They call me Wordsworth." It was then that Selig realized his mission. It was spreading the word - sharing his words with others!

From that day forth, Selig's steps were light and filled with purpose. Ever the collector, he added new words as it pleased him. But now, whenever he felt word-heavy, he discovered

the ideal places to sprinkle, disburse, and broadcast them.

In that way, a baker whose pastries had always been ignored found his shop filled with a mob of hungry customers. When the baker's back was turned, Selig, on a macaroon break, had tossed some of his favorite words into the air. Crispy and crunchy landed next to the crumpets. Scrumptious fell against a loaf of pumpernickel. Luscious leaned against a layer cake. "Upon my word! How lucky I am!" the baker exclaimed when he turned back and saw his voracious new customers.

Neighbors realized they were bickering when the words fuss, hubbub, and jibber-jabber rained down on them... and stopped their fighting.

Selig watched them grow still and gaze kindly upon one another after he cast hush, harmony, and chum in their direction.

And so, by word of mouth, the legend began.... "It's Wordsworth," people would whisper, when, suddenly, the right word occurred to them. "HE is near," they would nod, knowingly. "Upon my word! How lucky we are!"

Years passed. Selig was a man now, also a myth. But while he delighted in his work, he found that, once again, he was lonely. "Solo," he sighed.

One day, after launching the words Umber, spry, and gusto toward an aging, unhappy man, Selig heard a sound on the breeze. A single, pulsing, marvelous note floated through the air and found its way straight into his heart. "Mellifluous!" he exclaimed.

Pursuing that perfect note, Selig found a young woman seated by a lake, playing a lute. Suddenly, his heart was aflutter. Tremulously he asked, "M-m-may I have a word with you? Wh-wh-what is your name?" "They call me Melody," the woman sang out. The music of her voice, combined with the charm of her words, was, to Selig, the sweetest of all songs.

It was love at first listen. Together, they journeyed back to Selig's hometown, to his mother and father. What a reunion! How his mother smiled when she saw them! Worried that they looked thin, she cooked Selig's favorite foods - brisket, dumplings, plum crumble, strudel, and, of course, macaroons. To comfort their tired feet, Selig's father cobbled the couple his sturdiest shoes.

Rested and restored, Selig resumed his life's work, joyfully gathering and scattering words on the wind. Since then, word by word, legions of lucky people have discovered and delighted in them.

You too may find yourself lucky if, one day, while you are thinking or writing or simply speaking, the perfect word just seems to come to you. If so, you'll know that Selig is near. And on special days, if you feel like humming or suddenly bursting into song, you'll know that Melody is with him. "Upon my word!" you may say. "How lucky I am!"